

The Price of a Design Parameter

Bank Valuations in the Digital Euro Legislative Process

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Question. The principal financial-stability concern surrounding a retail central bank digital currency is deposit flight from commercial banks. The digital euro addresses this risk through concrete design parameters, including a holding limit, rules for corporate holdings, fee caps and access requirements. This paper asks whether equity markets priced these design choices during the European legislative process, and whether the response was larger for firms with greater economic exposure.

Data and identification. I assemble 26 legislative and central-bank events between 2023 and 2026, of which 22 verified event dates enter the pre-specified estimation sample, and code their contemporaneously available design content separately for banks, payment providers and device gatekeepers. I combine these events with daily equity returns for 49 listed firms, pre-proposal EBA measures of bank deposit exposure, and the published record of 309 disclosed meetings between legislators and interest representatives. The main specification is a two-stage event study. Abnormal returns are first estimated from market-factor models; the second stage relates firm-event abnormal returns to exposure interacted with the coded direction of each event, with firm and event fixed effects. Identification therefore comes from cross-sectional differences in exposure on the same event day and from sign changes in the coded design content across events.

Findings. In the pre-specified bank-exposure specification, a euro-area bank one standard deviation more deposit-funded gains 0.05 percentage points more on an event that limits the digital euro (permutation $p = 0.47$). Conservative release-time alignment raises the estimate to roughly 0.15–0.17 percentage points, providing some evidence of a small effect but not a robust large effect across inference procedures. Events that set or signal a design parameter show no detectable valuation effect. The 95% confidence bounds exclude effects of the magnitude documented for early digital-euro announcements by a wide margin. As a positive control, using predetermined exposure and strictly pre-event factor loadings, the same design detects a substantially larger response on the day of the October 2020 Eurosystem report.

Interpretation and contribution. The results suggest that markets reacted more strongly to early news about whether a digital euro would exist than to the later legislative calibration of its parameters. This is not because the parameters were politically unimportant: the negotiation record shows intense contestation, with the banking side the most frequent private counterparty. The paper contributes a market-based test of deposit-flight risk from CBDC design, an event-level coding of the digital euro legislative process, and a new public dataset on the political economy of that process.

Keywords: central bank digital currency; digital euro; financial stability; deposit flight; banking; event study; political economy of regulation.